

Puppy Vaccination & First 48 Hours: The At-Home Survival Checklist

For new puppies navigating their first rounds of shots. Written by a 10-year dog parent, cross-checked with AVMA guidelines.

Important: This checklist helps you manage normal vaccine side effects and recognize true emergencies. It is not a substitute for veterinary care. If your puppy is struggling to breathe or experiencing severe swelling, go to the Emergency Vet immediately.



Section 1: The "Go to the ER Now" Red Flags

Watch for these in the first 1-4 hours after the vet visit. If you see ANY of these, do not wait. Call your vet or head to the ER immediately.

- ☐ **Facial Swelling:** Puffy eyes, swollen muzzle, or hives breaking out on the belly.
 - ☐ **Breathing Issues:** Heavy, labored breathing, wheezing, or pale/blue gums.
 - ☐ **Severe Vomiting/Diarrhea:** Not just one loose stool, but repeated, violent vomiting or diarrhea.
 - ☐ **Collapse:** Sudden extreme weakness, unable to stand, or fainting.
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Section 2: What is 100% Normal (Don't Panic)

These are common, mild immune responses. They mean the vaccine is working. They should resolve within 24-48 hours.

- ☐ **Lethargy:** Sleeping heavily for the rest of the day. (Let them sleep!)
 - ☐ **Mild Fever:** Feeling a little warm to the touch.
 - ☐ **Loss of Appetite:** Skipping a meal or eating less than usual tonight.
 - ☐ **Soreness at the Injection Site:** Yipping if you pick them up under the arms or touch their neck/shoulder.
 - ☐ **A Small Bump:** A painless, pea-sized lump where the needle went in (can take 2-3 weeks to fully disappear).
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Section 3: The 48-Hour Home Care Plan

How to keep them comfortable tonight and tomorrow.

Tonight (0-12 Hours Post-Vaccine)

- ☐ **Create a Quiet Zone:** Set up their crate or bed in a dim, quiet room away from loud kids or other pets.
- ☐ **Lift with Care:** If you need to carry them outside to pee, scoop them from the chest and rump. Avoid grabbing them under the arms (the injection site is usually on the shoulder or back).
- ☐ **Hydration over Food:** If they refuse dinner, don't force it. Add a splash of low-sodium chicken broth to their water bowl to encourage drinking.

- ☐ **Skip the Walk:** No strenuous exercise or intense play today. Just short, calm bathroom breaks in your own yard.

Tomorrow (12-48 Hours Post-Vaccine)

- ☐ **Monitor the Soreness:** They should be moving a bit easier today.
- ☐ **Check the Injection Site:** Look for any excessive heat, oozing, or rapid growth of the bump.
- ☐ **Resume Normal Diet:** Offer their regular food. If they are still completely refusing food after 24 hours, call your vet for advice.

Section 4: Critical "Do NOT Do" List

- **DO NOT** give human pain meds (Tylenol, Advil, Aspirin). They are highly toxic and can be fatal to puppies.
- **DO NOT** take them to the dog park or pet store. Until their final round of shots (usually around 16 weeks), they are still vulnerable to Parvo and Distemper.
- **DO NOT** massage the injection site vigorously if they are yelping. Gentle petting is fine, but leave the sore muscle alone.
- **DO NOT** panic if they are just sleepy. Sleep is how their tiny bodies build immunity.

Section 5: The Standard Vaccine Timeline (Quick Reference)

Always follow your specific vet's schedule, but this is the general roadmap.

- **6-8 Weeks:** First DA2PP (Distemper, Adenovirus, Parainfluenza, Parvo)
- **10-12 Weeks:** Second DA2PP + Optional Lifestyle Vaccines (Bordetella/Kennel Cough, Lyme, Leptospirosis)
- **14-16 Weeks:** Third DA2PP + Rabies (Required by law)

This guide was created by PetHealthNotes.com. For a digital health vault, automated vaccine reminders, and symptom logging, download the free PetHealthNotes App today.